

12 Tips for Better Sleep Hygiene

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Do you ever find yourself staring at the ceiling, wondering if you'll ever fall asleep? Or maybe you wake up thinking it's time to get up, but it's actually 2 a.m.?

If you're in need of better sleep, it may be time to consider your sleep hygiene — and how your habits may be preventing you from getting the quality sleep you need.

Let's explore what sleep hygiene is and the adjustments you can make to your daytime and nighttime habits to enhance your sleep.

[What is sleep hygiene?](#)

Sleep hygiene refers to the healthy sleep habits that promote a good night's sleep. These habits encourage a regular, steady routine that helps regulate the body's circadian rhythm, the [internal "clock"](#) that controls sleep and wakefulness.

Good sleep hygiene is important because of the crucial role it plays in maintaining both mental and physical health, as well as overall quality of life.

It can include behaviors that a person does before bed, as well as behaviors they practice during the day, such as:

- evening routines
- [food and drink choices](#)
- stress management

Let's take a closer look at 12 ways to improve your sleep hygiene for better sleep.

[1. Keep a consistent sleep schedule](#)

Try to go to sleep and wake up at [around the same time](#) every day, even on weekends. This reinforces your body's sleep cycle, making it easier for you to fall asleep and wake up each day.

[2. Create a relaxing bedtime routine — and stick with it](#)

A relaxing bedtime routine helps you unwind so that you're ready to sleep. This may help you fall asleep more quickly.

Allow approximately [60 minutesTrusted SourceTrusted SourceTrusted Source](#) for your bedtime routine before you go to sleep. Your routine can include whatever makes you feel relaxed, unless it involves a device that emits blue light.

Here are some ideas:

- **Take a warm bath or shower:** Not only is [warm water](#) relaxing in the moment, but the drop in your body temperature as you cool down afterward may make you feel sleepy.
- **Try some gentle stretches:** [Stretches](#) can help your muscles relax and release tension. Alternatively, people can try relaxing forms of yoga.
- **Meditation:** Taking a few minutes to meditate, even if only briefly, may help calm your body and mind.
- **Relaxing music:** Try listening to soothing music or ambient sounds while focusing on your [breathing](#).
- **Reading:** Spend time reading a book, but try to avoid electronic reading devices that emit blue light.

Avoid anything stressful or overly stimulating, such as emotional conversations or work.

[3. Stop using electronic devices before you go to sleep](#)

Electronic devices, such as your phone, emit bright light, which [can interfereTrusted SourceTrusted SourceTrusted Source](#) with melatonin levels in the body. Melatonin is a hormone that regulates your sleep-wake cycle. It's similar to how seeing sunlight can make you feel more awake.

Devices can also keep your brain alert, even when you're not actively using them. For example, message notifications, buzzing, and light from a phone on your nightstand can interrupt your sleep.

Keeping a phone within reach may also encourage you to use it more, especially if you are having trouble falling asleep. This could create a vicious cycle.

You can reduce the effects of electronics on sleep by:

- turning off any unnecessary devices overnight
- using blue light filters on screens
- keeping phones out of the bedroom
- using device settings to limit noise, light, and notifications

4. Exercise regularly

As little as [10 minutes](#) of walking per day can improve your sleep quality and overall health. Exercising outside during the daytime may further enhance the benefits, as exposure to [natural light](#) helps regulate your sleep cycle.

If you can't get outside, don't worry. Regular indoor [exercise](#) can also help you sleep better.

If you want to do some type of activity later in the evening, try doing stretches or [yoga](#).

5. Limit your caffeine intake

Although it's usually best to limit your caffeine intake to the morning hours, keep in mind that people have varying degrees of [tolerance to caffeine](#).

Some people may be able to stretch their consumption to midafternoon, while others might need to cut themselves off much earlier in order to fall asleep easily.

The less caffeine you consume, the more sensitive you may be to its effects.

6. Make your sleep environment work for you

For most people, a bedroom temperature between around [65°F and 68°F](#) (18.3°C and 20°C) is the optimal temperature for sleeping.

It's also important to make sure you have a comfortable [mattress](#), [pillows](#), and bed [linens](#). The more comfortable you are, the easier it may be to fall asleep and stay asleep.

Additionally, if your bedroom is flooded with too much light, consider using [blackout curtains](#) or an [eye mask](#) to keep your sleep environment as dark as possible.

Mattress and sleep quality

“A mattress that can provide comfort and support will allow you to have a restful sleep. The type of mattress and degree of firmness is based on personal preference. In general, an old mattress more than 10 years old or with visible sagging will not be comfortable or supportive.

A mattress that helps you maintain spinal alignment while you sleep is important to help the structures surrounding the spine relax and recover during sleep.” – *Angelica Balingit, MD*

7. Use your bed only for sleep and sex

When you have a comfortable bed, it might be tempting to use it for reading, working, talking on the phone, watching TV, or other activities.

However, try to use your bed for sleep and sex only. This may help strengthen your brain's association between your bed and sleep, making it easier to relax.

Reading may be one way you relax before going to sleep, but even books can be disruptive to your sleep if they keep your brain alert. Try reading on the couch before moving to your bed instead.

8. Go to bed only when you're tired

If you're not tired, avoid lying in bed while you [toss and turn](#). Instead, try doing a relaxing activity until you start to feel tired, then head to bed.

If you don't fall asleep for a long time after going to bed, get up. Being unable to fall asleep may cause you to become frustrated or stressed, which can keep you awake even longer.

Once you get out of bed, do something to help you unwind, like reading on the couch or stretching until you're tired enough to go back to bed.

9. Limit napping — or avoid it if you can

[Napping](#) during the day can make it harder to fall asleep later and may increase your likelihood of waking up during the night.

10. Manage stress before going to bed

Thinking about things you're worried about can keep you awake at night. To help prevent your [worries](#) from keeping you awake:

- **Write them down:** Write down your worries or tasks before going to bed to help get them out of your head. Prioritize what you need to do tomorrow and the rest of the week, then try to relax.
- **Try a weighted blanket:** Some people find that a [weighted blanket](#) helps with anxiety and insomnia.
- **Try meditation:** Meditating before bed may help calm your mind.

11. Limit large meals before bed

12. Manage your light exposure

Spending time in natural light can help manage your circadian rhythm. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) recommends getting at least [30 minutes](#) of safe sunlight exposure during the daytime, ideally in the morning.

Limiting light exposure after sunset may help benefit your sleep and support the production of hormones and chemicals necessary for sleep. You can do this by:

- using warm light in the rooms you spend time in before bed
- turning off extra lights in the hours before bed
- dimming lights a few hours before bed, if possible
- setting your electronic devices to go into “night” mode after sunset, which reduces blue light exposure

The bottom line

Sleep hygiene is about having [healthy sleep habits](#). Your behaviors, both during the day and around bedtime, can affect the quality of your sleep.

If you have a hard time falling or staying asleep, you can try several strategies to [fall asleep faster](#) — and stay sleeping for hours at a time. Most of these involve improving your sleep hygiene.

Sticking to a schedule, having a relaxing bedtime routine, exercising regularly, keeping your bedroom dark and at a [comfortable temperature](#), and being mindful of caffeine intake can all impact the quality of your sleep.

If you continue to have issues with your sleep patterns or insomnia, be sure to follow up with your doctor. They can determine whether an underlying condition is causing your [sleep problems](#) and provide the necessary treatment.

30-Day challenge
